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digit.in/NASARocketscience

Space Age

perform experiments and posit theories for explanation, but the central condition, is the reliability of results. If nothing else, the worst case scenario is that we learn what doesn't hold. Yet what most people don't realize, is that even in the best case scenario, there is always a margin of error. Even if it is inconceivably small, error (or think of it as uncertainty) must always exist. Science is not an exact science.

In a way, the whole system of Science is a very accurate (and precise) superstition, and all theories and explanations are just logically convincing sells. Yet, in another way, superstition is a weak science (with mostly illogical sells). All that matters from any perspective, is that there are results. If believing a superstition and following its rituals increases the odds of success, that's good enough reason to continue! Much like the argument behind Pascal's Wager, better safe than sorry!

So without further ado, we present to you, a range of tried and tested superstitions employed by successful space agencies from across the globe!

Space Superstitions Galore!

If you're a long time reader of this magazine, we're assuming that you're decently knowledgeable and that you've probably heard of Yuri Gagarin, the first human to reach space. On 12 April, 1961, on the way to the launch site, he finally felt the magnitude of the feat he was about to set out to accomplish. Like any nervous person, he got an insurmountable urge to urinate. Unable to hold it in, he asked the bus to stop, unzipped his space suit and relieved himself on the tyre of the bus. Lo and behold, his mission was a success, and future Russian cosmonauts took this critical detail of the proceedings to heart, replicating it without fail.

Space Superstition No. 1! If you're a spacebound Russian male taking off from the Baikonur Cosmodrome in Kazakhstan, take a leak on the right-side back tyre of the bus that takes you to the launchpad! (Ladies bring their urine in vials, in case you were wondering.)

Gagarin's was the first successful launch, and the aim being to increase the odds of success, any deviation from that process would be risking failure. It's no

wonder Yuri Gagarin's actions became a template for many rituals of present day procedures. Strapped in and with nothing to do just before launch, he asked mission control to play him some music. They obliged with a collection of Russian love songs. Today they oblige with a wider variety, after ceremoniously playing the original songs played to Gagarin.

Another Russian space superstition relating to (but not inspired by) Yuri Gagarin is the tradition of signing in the guestbook of Gagarin's office in Zvyozdny Gorodok. Since his passing, Gagarin's office has been maintained to resemble its state as it was while he walked the earth. Some time

itself. Every crew member also signs a wall in the museum at Baikonur, after the customary signing of the bedroom door that signifies their last night on Earth. After successful reentry and recovery, astronauts sometimes also sign the charred outer shell of their space capsule.

Baikonur is the first and largest operational space launch facility in the world, having been the launch site of many successful missions (and a few major mishaps) over more than 50 years. There is a boulevard at Baikonur called the Avenue of Heroes, where a tree is poignantly planted for every launch that takes place. Even without delving in superstitions, this boule-



A sight no cosmonaut ever gets to see.

between training and take-off, soon-to-be space goers make it a point to visit this office, which is an important part of the space travel heritage of humankind. Gagarin's guestbook contains the signatures of all of the hundreds of cosmonauts who have travelled to space from the Baikonur Cosmodrome. Also, none of these cosmonauts have seen their rocket ship being towed to the launch site, because they are superstitiously forbidden to do so. Instead, they have to go for a haircut.

Signatures have come to be the conventional representative mark of any individual, and people who have an increased probability of not existing in the near future often feel better by making their mark while they can. The crew of a space flight do this by recording their signature on a number of places other than Gagarin's guestbook, beginning with the official signing off of the spaceship

ward can be considered sacred. The trees represent every mission and its members, a living legacy of those who returned, and a memorial for those who did not. Speaking of the dead, you must be dreaming if you ever hear of a Russian space mission launching on the 24th of October. This fated date marks two terrible tragedies, pre-launch disasters that claimed the lives of more than a hundred people in 1960 and 1963. Since then, October 24 is stay-on-earth day. The launch crew also has a tradition of writing a woman's name in the frosting that forms on the supercooled pipes during fueling. Someone skipped this once, 47 people died. Needless to say, it is a permanent ritual since then.

On a lighter note, a superstition on the theatrical level of Space Superstition No.1 - On the night before launch, the cosmonauts watch a movie. And not just any movie, they watch *The White Sun of*